

SUBIR HALDER



INFERNO

100-kottah plot (roughly the area that was burnt down in Burrabazar) in the middle of the city is a virtual gold mine. Kolkata allegedly has around 6,000 illegal buildings of which 300 are in Burrabazar. There are over 500 unsafe buildings, in the market, and fire is a regular occurrence in the area. Only a week before this incident, there was a blaze in another area of the market which was, thankfully, controlled.

Almost all major buildings of Kolkata have little or no fire safety measures. Nandaram, which has been featured in local papers as one of the most unsafe buildings in the city was built in 1976 with an initial plan of six

floors that rapidly expanded to 18. The municipal corporation had razed the top floors to bring it down to 13, but couldn't proceed further due to pressure from the traders as they claimed to have paid taxes regularly.

Although the Supreme Court had declared the entire property illegal 22 years ago, it continued to exist. Every market that shares the same history—from the underground Satynarayan AC market in Burrabazar that burned for three days in 2003, to the historic Firpo's in 2002—had been stuffed with new shops in a matter of weeks after their respective disasters. The legendary New Market still operates out of the blackened walls of its 1985 fire.

Allegations of sabotage have been rife around Nandaram. Like many other properties in Burrabazar, no one

ANGRY FUMES

- Lives lost: One, of a trader named T.K. Vaid who died of a heart attack.
- Injured: One fireman lost his eyes while a few others suffered minor injuries.
- Area gutted: Roughly 100-kottahs including 12 buildings.
- Property destroyed: Allegedly estimated at Rs 2,500 crore.
- Firemen who fought with the flames: 300
- Fire engines deployed: 45
- Fire tenders that could work effectively at a time: 2

knows who owns the market. According to the police, Manik Chand Sethia, director of a company called Brabourne Properties, collects rent from some of the traders in the market, but no charges have been pressed against him. Some official records also claim a plywood company and a tea trader were Nandaram's original owners.

Nevertheless, as traders sift through the pile of burnt material, they say people have already sought lease of their properties. They know that their *gaddis* might just have to be shifted elsewhere, for the Nandaram market has become too hot to handle. ■

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